

INTELLIGENCE BRIEF / N° 162 · HOT

Fireworks AI

AI Infrastructure · Inference Cloud for Open Models · Redwood City, California (founded 2022) · Private (\$17.5B; \$1.505B Series D, Jul 2026)

Fireworks AI, the Redwood City inference cloud founded by the Meta engineers behind PyTorch, announced a \$1.505B Series D at a \$17.5B valuation on 16 July 2026, led by Atreides, Index Ventures and TCV with Nvidia participating, as annualised revenue passed \$1B, fivefold in a year on the company's figures.

77
OPPORTUNITY / 100

TIMING WINDOW

HOT

SERIES

F1

RECOMMENDED TEAM

Visa Cash App
Racing Bulls

ACTION HORIZON

6-10 WKS

THE CASE

Bloomberg reported on 27 May that Fireworks was in talks at \$15B with Index co-leading; the round priced above that on 16 July at \$17.5B, led by Atreides Management, Index Ventures and TCV, with Nvidia, Lightspeed, Evantic, Bessemer, Menlo, Insight, Ontario Teachers' and Lone Pine participating. It follows a \$250M Series C at \$4B in October 2025, a fourfold step in nine months; total funding is about \$1.8B (reported). The company says annualised revenue passed \$1B, up fivefold, and tokens served rose from 15 to over 40 trillion a day. Headcount goes from about 200 to 600 by year-end.

Inference has been sold to the grid twice: Groq at McLaren since September 2025 and CoreWeave at Aston Martin since May 2025, each signed in the year the vendor needed a public story. Fireworks is the inference company whose customers, Uber, DoorDash, Notion, Samsung and Verizon, are names a paddock recognises, and it has no seat. A \$17.5B private company with \$1B of revenue has the public market as its next audience.

WHY NOW

The round closed on 16 July and headcount is set to triple by December; brand budgets follow the hiring plan. The United States GP in October and the Las Vegas GP in November fall inside the window, and teams close 2027 rosters in the fourth quarter.

PROOF POINTS — EVERY FIGURE VERIFIED TO A PRIMARY SOURCE (SEE P.2)

\$1.505B

\$1.505B Series D at a \$17.5B post-money valuation, led by Atreides Management, Index Ventures and TCV (comp...

\$1B

Annualised revenue run-rate above \$1B, up fivefold year on year (company statement, Jul 2026; not audited)

\$15B

Bloomberg reported on 27 May that Fireworks was in talks at \$15B with Index co-leading;

\$17.5B

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\$250M

It follows a \$250M Series C at \$4B in October 2025, a fourfold step in nine months;

\$1.8B

total funding is about \$1.8B (reported).

GRID FIT — CATEGORY-WHITESPACE CHECK ACROSS THE F1 GRID (SPONSOR TABLE; 49 OF 346 PARTNER ROWS CATEGORISED)

Visa Cash App Racing Bulls ◆ RECOMMENDED	OPEN	no rival in this category lane
McLaren F1 Team	TAKEN	Dell Technologies, Google Cloud
Aston Martin Aramco F1 Team	TAKEN	CoreWeave, NetApp
Mercedes-AMG Petronas F1 Team	TAKEN	Microsoft

BOTTOM LINE

A \$1.505B Series D at \$17.5B, revenue past \$1B on the company's figures and headcount tripling put Fireworks at peak brand-investment authority. Racing Bulls has the real-time data stack and no inference partner, Groq at McLaren and CoreWeave at Aston Martin proved the category, and two US races remain inside the window.

WHY VISA CASH APP RACING BULLS

Racing Bulls has built the grid's most explicit real-time data stack without an inference layer: Confluent streams more than a million data points a second between car, pit wall and factory, Dynatrace is Official Observability and Performance Analytics partner, RebelDot builds software, and there is no AI-inference, cloud or model partner. Faenza and the Milton Keynes aero site are fed by that stream. A challenger team with a younger audience suits a developer-first brand, priced below the works teams.

VALUE TO VISA CASH APP RACING BULLS — MODE A (TECH IN THE CAR / CHAMPIONSHIP)

MODE A - operational. The inference layer on the Confluent stream: open-weight models fine-tuned on the team's own telemetry and strategy history, served at low latency for engineer copilots during sessions and for post-session analysis, hosted by Fireworks so no cost-cap capital is spent. Fireworks runs this shape for Uber and DoorDash. Part of the consideration in inference credits; for Fireworks, a reference deployment to show enterprise buyers.

DEAL ARCHITECTURE

Entry as Official AI Inference Partner. **THREE YEARS**, 2027-2029, spanning the hiring plan and any listing window. Estimated \$3-5M a year, part-payable in inference credits. Scope: sidepod or halo placement, naming of the team's model environment, US-race hospitality for enterprise accounts, engineering content from Faenza.

PRIMARY DECISION-MAKER

Lin Qiao

CEO & CO-FOUNDER, FIREWORKS AI · **VERIFIED**

Qiao led PyTorch at Meta as Senior Director of Engineering before founding Fireworks in 2022 with six PyTorch colleagues; she fronts every raise. Path: Dmytro Dzhulgakov, CTO and Co-Founder. No chief marketing officer, COO, chief revenue officer or CFO is named on the company's listings.

OPENING ANGLE

Lead with the stack that lacks a brain.

“Lin, Racing Bulls streams a million data points a second and has no inference partner on top of it. You have just raised \$1.5B at \$17.5B with revenue past \$1B; Groq and CoreWeave took their seats at this stage. 25 minutes before Austin?”

SCORE COMPOSITION

TIMING 17 / 20 Round 16 Jul; Austin and Las Vegas inside the window.	CAPACITY 19 / 20 \$1.5B raise at \$17.5B; \$1B+ run-rate (company figure).	BRAND FIT 14 / 20 Developer-first B2B brand; enterprise names to show.	URGENCY 12 / 20 No listing stated; headcount tripling by December.	OPS FIT 15 / 20 MODE A: inference on the Confluent stream; lane open.
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RISKS & COUNTERS

REVENUE IS A COMPANY FIGURE The \$1B run-rate and fivefold growth are company statements, not audited; Cursor was once over half of revenue. **Counter:** Anchor capacity on the closed round; ask for the customer mix on the call.

TWO INFERENCE LOGOS ALREADY Groq at McLaren and CoreWeave at Aston Martin own the narrative; a third entrant can read as late. **Counter:** Sell the fine-tuned-on-your-data deployment on the Confluent stream, not a chip logo or a wind-tunnel name.

SOURCES — 22 OF 22 LOAD-BEARING CLAIMS VERIFIED

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- https://www.businesswire.com/news/home/20251028604819/en/Fireworks-AI-Raises-\$250M-Series-C-to-Lead-the-AI-Inference-Market